

LESSON 8

THE SUBJUNCTIVE FUTURE: THE IMPERFECT TENSE

SECTION 1: REVIEW OF LESSON 7

Quick Summary In Lesson 7, we tackled “weak roots”—verbs that contain an Alaph (ا) or Yodh (ي). We saw that while they can lose or transform their weak consonants in conjugation (e.g.,

$$^{\circ} - M - R$$

'EMAR

;

$$\dot{H} - Z - Y$$

$$HZ\bar{A}$$

), they still behave syntactically like normal verbs.

5-Question Warm-Up Drill (*Answers in Section 9*) 1. What does the Yodh in a III-Yodh verb turn into in the 3rd masc singular perfect (e.g., *ḥ-z-y*)? 2. Translate: 'Emar *malkā*. 3. Identify the root of *īda* ' (he knew). 4. Translate: 'Aytāw-*hy* (bring him!). Why is the suffix *-hy* used instead of *-eh*? 5. How would you say "I saw" (1 c.sg. of *ḥ-z-y*)?

SECTION 2: THE SEMITIC PREFIX CONJUGATION – OVERVIEW

We have learned that the Participle handles the *Present* (ongoing action) and the *Perfect* (Suffix Conjugation) handles the *Past* (completed action).

How does Syriac talk about the Future or expressing wishes/commands? It uses the **Imperfect Tense**, often called the “Prefix Conjugation.”

Cross-Linguistic Comparison: The Imperfect In all Semitic languages, the Imperfect adds prefixes (*n-*, *t-*, *ʾ-*, *y-*, etc.) to the root to indicate the person, while suffixes are used to indicate plural number. * **Hebrew Qal**

Imperfect: יִכְתֹּב (*yiktōb* — he will write), יִכְתֹּבִי (*'ektōb* — I will write). *

Arabic Form I Imperfect: يَكْتُبُ (*yaktubu* — he writes/will write), أَكْتُبُ

(*'aktubu* — I write). * **Syriac Peal Imperfect:** ܬܠܝܬܐܒ (*nektūb* — he will write), ܬܠܝܬܐܒܝ (*'ektūb* — I will write).

Crucial Note on Syriac vs. Hebrew/Arabic: In Hebrew and Arabic, the 3rd person masculine prefix is **y-** (*ya-* or *yi-*). In standard Syriac, the 3rd person prefix shifted to **n-** (*ne-*).

SECTION 3: MORPHOLOGY AND SYNTAX OF THE IMPERFECT

1. Forming the Peal Imperfect For a strong root like *k-t-b*, the base vocalization of the imperfect shifts to an *ū* (Waw) theme vowel between the second and third consonant: *-ktūb*. We then add the person-marking prefixes: * *n-* (He / They m) → *n-ek-tūb* → **nektūb** (He will write). * *t-* (You / She / They f) → **tektūb** (You will write / She will write). * *'-* (I) → **'ektūb** (I will write).

2. Syntax: The Simple Future By itself, the Imperfect functions as a simple future tense. * *Nektūb Yūḥannan meltā*. (Yukhannan will write a word). * *Tehze tammān malkā*. (You will see a king there).

3. Syntax: The Subjunctive / Purpose (**d- + Imperfect)** Syriac uses the Imperfect heavily for purpose clauses, wishes, and commands. It accomplishes this by attaching the relative particle **d-** directly to the Imperfect verb. This corresponds to the Greek subjunctive with ἵνα (*hina*). * *'Etā d-neḥze* = He came **in order that he might see**. * *'Āmer-nā d-tektūb* = I say **that you should write**.

SECTION 4: IMPERFECT TENSE PARADIGMS (PEAL, PAAEL, APHEL)

1. The Peal Imperfect Conjugation (Root **q-ṭ-l)** In the Peal, the prefix has an *e* vowel in modern pronunciation (or *i* historically), and the theme vowel is usually *ū* (or *a* for gutturals).

PERSON	ESTRANGELA	TRANSLIT	TRANSLATION	PREFIX	SUFFIX
3 m.sg.	ܢܥܬܘܠ	neqṭūl	he will kill	n-	(none)
3 f.sg.	ܬܥܬܘܠܐ	teqṭūl	she will kill	t-	(none)
2 m.sg.	ܬܥܬܘܠܐ	teqṭūl	you (m) will kill	t-	(none)
2 f.sg.	ܬܥܬܘܠܝܢ	teqṭlīn	you (f) will kill	t-	-īn
1 c.sg.	ܐܥܬܘܠ	'eqṭūl	I will kill	' -	(none)
3 m.pl.	ܢܥܬܠܘܢ	neqṭlūn	they (m) will kill	n-	-ūn
3 f.pl.	ܬܥܬܠܢ	neqṭlān	they (f) will kill	n-	-ān
1 c.pl.	ܢܥܬܘܠ	neqṭūl	we will kill	n-	(none)

Warning: The forms for “He will kill” (neqṭūl) and “We will kill” (neqṭūl) are identical in spelling and pronunciation! Context almost always makes it obvious.

2. The Paael Imperfect (Root **q-d-š, to sanctify)** In the derived stems (Paael and Aphel), the prefix vowel is *a* rather than *e*. For Paael, the middle root letter is doubled (represented by a hard pronunciation or dot).

PERSON	ESTRANGELA	TRANSLIT	TRANSLATION
3 m.sg.	ܐܢܩܕܕܝܫ	nqaddeš	he will sanctify
1 c.sg.	ܐܢܩܕܝܫ	'aqaddeš	I will sanctify
3 m.pl.	ܐܢܩܕܕܝܫܘܢ	nqaddšūn	they will sanctify
1 c.pl.	ܐܢܩܕܝܫ	nqaddeš	we will sanctify

3. The Aphel Imperfect (Root **p-q, Aphel = **'appiq** to bring out)** In the Aphel, the original *'a-* prefix of the perfect drops out, and the imperfect prefix takes its place with an *a* vowel. The theme vowel is usually *e* or *i*.

PERSON	ESTRANGELA	TRANSLIT	TRANSLATION
3 m.sg.	ﻣﺎﻗ	nappēš / nappiq	he will bring out
1 c.sg.	ﻣﺎﻗﻚ	'appiq	I will bring out
3 m.pl.	ﻣﺎﻗﻮﻥ	nappqūn	they will bring out

SECTION 5: THE SUBJUNCTIVE FLOW

Observe how the purpose clause flows in translation:

PRIMARY ACTION (PAST/ PRESENT)	SUBJUNCTIVE CLAUSE (D- + IMPERFECT)	TRANSLATION
'Etā malkā (The king came)	d-neqtūl l-eh (that he might kill him)	The king came in order to kill him.
Yūḥannan 'ābed nūhrā (Yukhannan makes light)	d-neḥzūn 'ammā (that the people might see)	Yukhannan makes light so that the people will see.

SECTION 6: VOCABULARY (TIME, JUDGMENT & ROYAL COURT)

ROOT/NOUN	TRANSLITERATION	MEANING	RELATED CONCEPT
זכר / זמן	zban / zabnā	time	Temporal boundary
דמא	‘ damā	until	Used with <i>d-</i> (until that)
דין / דיןא	dīn / dīnā	judgment, law	Eschatological judgment
עלם / עולם	‘ ālam / ‘ ālmā	world, eternity	Often <i>l-</i> ‘ ālam (forever)
יום / יומא	yūm / yūmā	day	Heb. <i>yōm</i>
ש.מ.ד.	shād (Peal)	to testify/witness	Court setting
גזר	gzar (Peal)	to decree/cut	Royal authority
י.ע.ב.	īteb (Peal)	to sit/enthroned	enthronement
ש.ח.ל.	q̄tal (Peal)	to kill	execution context
דחל / דחלתא	dḥal / deḥltā	fear/reverence	Root <i>d-ḥ-l</i> (to fear)
דנא	dān (Peal, Hollow)	to judge	Active verb of <i>dīmā</i>

SECTION 7: THE STORY – PART 8

The Threat Narrative note: The king uses the Subjunctive/Imperfect to express his threats and purpose concerning Yukhannan’s future.

Sentence 1 זמן יומא דמא קאם יוחנן דמא מלכא ד- qām Yūḥannan qdām malkā d-dīnā. qām (stood) Yūḥannan (John) qdām (before) malkā (the-king) d-dīnā (of-judgment). → Yukhannan stood before the king of judgment.

Sentence 2 ומלכא יתב למ w-īteb malkā w- ‘ emar l-ēh: w-īteb (and-sat) malkā (the-king) w- ‘ emar (and-said) l-ēh (to-him): → And the king sat and said to him:

Sentence 3 עבדא דמא דאברהם דיןא, ד- ‘ e ‘ bed bīšā lāk! ‘ ābed (doing/making) -nā (am-I) dīnā (judgment), d- (PURP) + ‘ e ‘ bed (1sg.IMPF.PEAL of ‘ -b-d, ‘do/make’ = “in order that I might do”) bīšā (evil) lāk (to-you)! → “I am rendering judgment, that I might do evil

to you!" Note: 'e' bed is a Peal imperfect 1sg in a purpose clause (introduced by d-), not a perfect or imperative. The construction d- + Imperfect corresponds to Greek ἵνα + subjunctive.

Sentence 4 לֹא תַעֲזֹב אֶת אֶרֶץ מִשְׁכַּנִּי וְהָרַגוּ אֶתְּךָ בְּיוֹם הַדִּינִי 'en lā
tešbūq 'ar ' -y, neqṭlūn lāk b-yūm dīnā! 'en (if) lā (not) tešbūq (you-will-
leave) 'ar ' -y (land-my), neqṭlūn (they-will-kill) lāk (to-you) b-yūm (in-
the-day) dīnā (of-judgment)! → “If you do not leave my land, they will kill
you in the day of judgment!”

Sentence 5 יְהֹנָתָן אָמַר לְיֵהוּא לֹא אֶפְחָד. Yūḥannan 'emar l-ēh: lā 'edḥal.
Yūḥannan (John) 'emar (said) l-ēh (to-him): lā (not) 'edḥal (I-will-fear).
→ Yukhannan said to him: “I will not fear.”

Sentence 6 ܕܠܗܐ ܕܠܗܐ ܕܠܗܐ ܕܠܗܐ ܕܠܗܐ 'etēt d- 'emar meltā
d-Alāhā l- 'ālmā. 'etēt (I-came) d- 'emar (that-I-might-say) meltā (the-
word) d-Alāhā (of-God) l- 'ālmā (to-the-world). → "I came in order to
speak the word of God to the world."

SECTION 8: EXERCISES

Exercise 1: Imperfect Identification Identify the person, gender, and number of the following Imperfect verbs. 1. נִכְתֹּב (nektūb) 2. תִּשְׁבְּקֻן (tešbqūn) 3. נִבְדָּן (ne' bdān) 4. יִהְיֶה ('ehzē — root h-z-y)

Exercise 2: Conjugation Drill Conjugate the root *q-t-l* (to kill) in the Peal Imperfect for: 1. He will kill 2. We will kill 3. I will kill 4. They (m) will kill

Exercise 3: Translation Drill (Syriac → English) Translate the following future or subjunctive clauses. 1. Nfaq malkā d-neḥzē l-Yūḥannan. (Remember ḥ-z-y acts weak). 2. Lā neqtūl malkā l-gabrā ṭābā. 3. Tešbqūn l-baytkūn l- ʿālam. 4. Ktabt meltā d-yād ʿīn hnan šrārā.

Exercise 4: Production Drill (English → Syriac) Render the following sentences into Syriac transliteration using the Imperfect. 1. I will write the decree (*gzar*) in the day of judgment. 2. The king decreed (*gzar*, perfect) that he might kill the men (*gabrē*). 3. If you (m.sg) do not leave heaven, you will see God. 4. They (m.pl) will come to the kingdom. (Hint: *nēthūn* from ' -t-y).

Exercise 5: Reading Comprehension Re-read Section 7 and answer: 1. What does the king threaten to do to Yukhannan? 2. What is the condition the king sets? 3. What is Yukhannan's stated purpose for coming to the world?

SECTION 9: ANSWER KEY

Section 1 Warm-Up 1. It becomes a long ' Alaph (ā). Example: *ḥzā*. 2. The king said. 3. *y-d-* ' (to know). I-Yodh. 4. Because the suffix is attaching to a vowel-ending word (the Aphel imperative ' *aytāw*). 5. *ḥzēt* (I saw).

Exercise 1: Imperfect Identification 1. 3.m.sg or 1.c.pl (He will write / We will write) 2. 2.m.pl (You all will leave) 3. 3.f.pl (They [feminine] will do) 4. 1.c.sg (I will see)

Exercise 2: Conjugation Drill 1. neqṭūl 2. neqṭūl 3. ' eqṭūl 4. neqṭlūn

Exercise 3: Translation Drill 1. The king went out in order to see Yukhannan. 2. The king will not kill the good man. 3. You all will leave your house forever. 4. You wrote a word so that we might know the truth.

Exercise 4: Production Drill 1. ' Ektūb *gzar* b-yūm dīnā. 2. *Gzar malkā d-neqṭūl l-gabrē*. 3. ' En lā tešbūq šmayyā, teḥzē l-Alāhā. 4. *Nēthūn l-malkūtā*.

Exercise 5: Reading Comprehension 1. To kill him in the day of judgment.
2. If Yikhannan does not leave his land (“my land”). 3. To say/speak the word of God to the world.

SECTION 10: GRAMMATICAL SUMMARY

THE PEAL IMPERFECT (Root q-ṭ-l)

PERSON	SYRIAC	TRANSLIT
3 m.sg.	ܩܬܝܠ	neqṭūl (he will kill)
3 f.sg.	ܩܬܝܠܐ	teqṭūl (she will kill)
2 m.sg.	ܩܬܝܠܐ	teqṭūl (you will kill)
1 c.sg.	ܩܬܝܠܐ	’eqṭūl (I will kill)
3 m.pl.	ܩܬܝܠܝܢ	neqṭlūn (they will k.)
1 c.pl.	ܩܬܝܠܝܢ	neqṭūl (we will kill)

SYNTAX OF PURPOSE Verb 1 (Any Tense) + **d-** + Verb 2 (Imperfect) =
Purpose Clause *’Ezal (He went) d-ne ‘bed (in order to do) qyāmā (a covenant).*

SECTION 11: ADDITIONAL VOCABULARY

The following high-frequency words round out this lesson’s vocabulary to 30 terms.

ESTRANGELA	TRANSLITERATION	GENDER/TYPE	MEANING
קִרְיָה	qīrītā	f	village
לִשָּׁנָה	leššānā	m	tongue, language
עֲצָמָה	garmā	m	bone
קֶפֶז	kēpā	f	stone, rock
דָּג	nūnā	m	fish
עִיר	mdittā	f	city
שֶׁמֶשׁ	šemšā	m	sun
דֶּלֶת	tar‘ā	m	door, gate
שֶׁחַד	mešhā	m	oil
סֵלָה	ḥaylā	m	power, army
אָזְנוֹ	‘ednā	f	ear
עֵץ	qaysā	m	wood, tree
נָחַל	nahrā	m	river
סִבְרָה	sabrā	m	hope
סַחֲרָה	sahrā	m	moon
רֶגֶל	reglā	f	foot
שָׁלוֹם	šlāmā	m	peace
אֶרֶץ	‘atrā	m	place, country
עֵד	sāhdā	m	witness, martyr

SECTION 11: ADDITIONAL VOCABULARY

The following high-frequency words round out this lesson’s vocabulary to 30 terms.

ESTRANGELA	TRANSLITERATION	GENDER/TYPE	MEANING
כֶּסֶד	besrā	m	flesh
כְּחֹמֶל	ṭaybüttā	f	grace
כֶּרֶם	tawrā	m	bull, ox
כְּוֶהָל	’ūrḥā	f	way, road
כְּחֵלֶם	hayklā	m	temple, palace
כַּחַשׁ	‘aynā	f	eye
כֶּסֶף	pūmā	m	mouth
כְּחֹמֶל	pāraḥtā	f	bird
כְּחֹמֶל	ḥadūtā	f	joy
כְּחֹמֶל	ḥekmtā	f	wisdom
כְּחֹמֶל	ḥayyūtā	f	animal, beast
כֶּרֶם	pīrā	m	fruit
כֶּלֶב	kalbā	m	dog
כֶּרֶם	’erbā	m	sheep
כֶּרֶם	ṭūrā	m	mountain
כְּחֹמֶל	šūqā	m	street, market
כְּחֹמֶל	‘āqtā	f	distress, anguish
כֶּרֶם	nūrā	f	fire
כְּחֹמֶל	raḥmē	m.pl	mercy
כְּחֹמֶל	meḥartā	f	tomorrow
כֶּלֶב	zannā	m	time, era
כְּחֹמֶל	rešā	m	head (leadership)
כֶּלֶב	’in	conj	if
כְּחֹמֶל	’ōlyā	adv	perhaps
כְּחֹמֶל	p’āltā	f	trust, confidence
כְּחֹמֶל	deḥlā	m	fear
כְּחֹמֶל	yed’ā	m	knowledge